

Chapter 43-1

For a moment, the atmosphere was at a standstill.

After a long while, Bai Weiwei smiled bitterly, "So you're still standing on Liang Shi's side, aren't you? For her sake, you can give up anything."

"No." Xu Qingzhu took a deep breath, forcing herself to regain composure, "This isn't about what I want or don't want. You're asking me to trade someone else's interests with you."

"But you could just make the trade!" Bai Weiwei questioned her, "Isn't Minghui Jewelry very important to you? You've wanted to join the company since you were in school, you wanted to make a career, you wanted to restore it to its former glory. Look how capable you are now—you've already attracted attention as soon as you started, you're so close to your goal. Don't you want it?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled helplessly, "Of course I want it, but that doesn't mean I'll trade away Liang Shi's things for it."

"Then what can you trade with me?" Bai Weiwei asked.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her.

Their eyes met, and Bai Weiwei was the first to look away. She asked with a choked voice, "What else do you have to trade with me?"

"Let's trade with our years of friendship." Xu Qingzhu laughed coldly. Even though tears had already formed in her eyes, she still forced a smile, one even gentler than usual, "If you have that video, then you know I didn't deliberately hurt Chen Liuying—I was acting in self-defense."

Bai Weiwei's expression changed, but she immediately said, "You're talking nonsense."

"Whether I'm talking nonsense or not, you know best!" Xu Qingzhu glared at her, her gaze instantly sharp, "Weiwei, I truly considered you a friend. All those years between us can't be fake, but they can't compare to this one year with Chen Liuying?"

Bai Weiwei was momentarily speechless.

While she was organizing her words, Xu Qingzhu said coldly, "If you insist on releasing that video, then I'll also give you a gift."

Bai Weiwei frowned, "What?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't say. She just lowered her head, took out her phone, and called Sally, "Where are you two? Come in for a moment."

Almost as soon as she hung up, Sally and Lin Luoxi walked in.

Lin Luoxi even closed the restroom door and placed a "Under Maintenance" barrier outside.

The space, which wasn't small to begin with, suddenly became crowded.

When Bai Weiwei saw them, she laughed coldly, "So you're planning to use numbers to bully the few?"

"We're nowhere near that yet." Xu Qingzhu said, "Don't Chen Liuying's fans outnumber any of ours? You said you'd post the video online, but I didn't say you were bullying me."

"So you want to have a falling out with me?" Bai Weiwei was shocked.

Lin Luoxi couldn't stand listening anymore and clicked her tongue from the side, saying to Sally, "Do you smell something?"

Sally, who always cooperated seamlessly with her in such matters, asked, "Flower scent?"

"Mm." Lin Luoxi smiled, "What a big white lotus flower¹."

Bai Weiwei glared at her, "Lin Luoxi, stop being so passive-aggressive."

"Did I call you by name?" Lin Luoxi stood there with her arms crossed, looking at her with contempt, then glanced at Chen Liuying's face, "Maybe I was talking about the one next to you?"

Chen Liuying raised her head and met her gaze.

After a moment, she looked away without saying anything.

"See that, Bai Weiwei?" Lin Luoxi said, "You're the only one who's stupid."

"Lin Luoxi!" Bai Weiwei clenched her fists, "This is between me and Xu Qingzhu. Don't interfere."

Then she looked at Xu Qingzhu, "What do you want to say? Continue."

Xu Qingzhu said, "Show me your video."

Bai Weiwei: "..."

"What are you doing? Want to destroy the evidence?" Bai Weiwei accused angrily, "I already said, you just need to make Liang Shi give up that role and it'll be fine."

"As far as I know, the audition results aren't out yet. Why are you saying this? Do you know some inside information, or do you have no confidence in Chen Liuying?"

Xu Qingzhu had completely calmed down by now, her aura fully unleashed, her voice cold, her gaze fixed tightly on Bai Weiwei. Even though her heart was reluctant, she knew that reaching this point was no accident—she could only make a decisive cut.

Bai Weiwei was pressured by her aura into taking half a step back, but still tried to save face, "How could I not have confidence in Chen Liuying? If it weren't for Liang Shi getting connections with Zhao Ying, I wouldn't even consider her worth my attention."

"Then do you think Zhao Ying would support just anyone?" Xu Qingzhu continued questioning.

"That's all because of Zhao Xuning!" Bai Weiwei said the name through gritted teeth, then continued, "And besides, she's the third young miss of the Liang family—which production crew wouldn't want her? Having her means a walking haute couture² manufacturing machine, a topic queen. This drama will be popular before it even airs. Isn't she just constantly using her privileges? I'm just asking her to give up something that didn't belong to her in the first place."

"What belongs to her? What doesn't belong to her?" Xu Qingzhu's voice wasn't loud, but it carried extraordinary pressure, especially those cold eyes that no longer held any of their usual gentleness or affection, "Do you really think there's nothing sordid about your way of thinking?"

Bai Weiwei was suddenly scolded and became furious, "You!"

"What you should be doing now is improving Chen Liuying's acting skills, not using underhanded tactics to pressure me here." Xu Qingzhu said, "Everyone knows Chen Liuying's acting isn't good. What's so glorious about being better than her?"

Chen Liuying finally couldn't help but speak up, "Xu Qingzhu, that's quite hurtful to say."

"I can be even more hurtful." Xu Qingzhu glared at her, then said, "But weren't you the ones who hurt people first?"

"Post that video of yours if you want." Xu Qingzhu said, "I don't care, but asking Liang Shi to give up her role is im-pos-si-ble!"

Bai Weiwei was confused, "Why? Do you love her that much?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her, "Bai Weiwei, I should be asking you why. Is it because of that incident at Huayue International³ that you became like this? Did I not try to save you? That day I was called over by your message—I was the most innocent victim."

"You went to Huayue International to negotiate resources for Chen Liuying. I got implicated because of you, and I never said anything about it, did I? I considered you a friend, I wanted to comfort you, but what about you?" Xu Qingzhu laughed coldly, "Did you become unscrupulous for Chen Liuying's sake, or were you always like this—I just never saw your true nature?"

A tear fell from Bai Weiwei's eyes.

She was angry at first, then became expressionless, and after a while, she laughed coldly. When she finished laughing, she said, "Oh my, I'm really so moved. Xu Qingzhu, you consider me such a good friend that you won't listen to anything I say, and instead want to dictate my life. Why do you always act so high and mighty? It makes me sick, you know?"

"Why did I go to Huayue International to negotiate? Because that was part of my job!" Bai Weiwei scoffed, "If you really considered me a friend, how could you not know what my job entailed? How could you have that expression every time I mentioned Liang Shi?"

"You don't tell me things, I can't tell you my troubles. When I hit walls at work, when I drank until I threw up trying to secure resources again and again, what were you doing? You were busy preparing for your wedding with Liang Shi, you were busy being lovey-dovey with Liang Shi. Did you ever care about me? Are we even friends?! Is this how you treat me as a friend?"

By the end, her emotions had completely broken down.

But Xu Qingzhu gradually calmed down.

She was like an outsider observing all of this, observing Bai Weiwei's breakdown and hysteria.

Footnotes:

¹ White lotus flower: Chinese internet slang referring to someone who appears pure and innocent on the surface but is actually manipulative or scheming

² Haute couture: High-end, custom-made fashion design

³ Huayue International: A company name mentioned in the story's context